

THE WAY

Theology, Practice & Formation Architecture

Belief, practice, formation, sacred sources, ethics, holy time, children, ministry, and open questions

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Purpose: provide enough religious structure for the Way to be lived, taught, transmitted, and examined without prematurely pretending that unresolved theology is settled revelation.

1. Governing principle

The first generation of the Way should become deep enough to be practiced and transmitted, but not so rigid that provisional conclusions become untouchable dogma. Formation therefore begins with practices of attention, prayer, study, ethics, service, fellowship, and discernment, while theology advances through explicit evidence and confidence levels.

The tradition should never use uncertainty as an excuse for emptiness, nor certainty as an excuse for domination. Where the Assembly knows something only provisionally, it should say so. Where a practice is helpful before its final theology is settled, it may be practiced transparently as provisional.

Working maxim

Practice what can be practiced honestly. Teach what can be supported responsibly. Mark open questions as open. Revise when better evidence or understanding requires it.

1.1 Formation architecture in one view

Layer	Question	Primary instrument	Status
Theology	What do we currently understand about God, reality, humanity, revelation, evil, death, and the end?	Theological question map and doctrine records	Mostly open/provisional
Practice	How does a Companion actually live the Way?	Daily/weekly/yearly rhythms; prayer; study; service; fellowship	Provisional but usable
Formation	How does a person learn and mature?	Seeker orientation; Companion Foundations; Year One cycle; continuing formation	Operational draft
Ethics	How should power and conduct be ordered?	Ethical commitments + institutional integrity framework	Strongest/most settled layer
Sources	What testimony do we study and how?	Sacred-source methodology and evidence dossiers	Operational draft
Ministry	How are Teachers/Ministers/Stewards formed?	Competency-based formation and supervised practicum	Operational draft
Children	How do children learn without coercion?	Developmental family/children framework	Operational draft
Holy time	How does time carry memory and practice?	Daily, weekly, seasonal, annual rhythms	Provisional

2. Theology of knowledge: how claims become teachings

The Way retains the v0.6 sequence Encounter -> Testimony -> Interpretation -> Teaching -> Doctrine. v0.7 adds a formation rule: nobody should be required to affirm a proposition at a confidence level higher than the Assembly itself can justify.

A person may experience something as revelation. The community may receive the testimony respectfully. Interpretation then remains a human act subject to source criticism, comparison, reason, moral evaluation, historical context, prayer, and communal discernment.

Confidence level	Meaning	Formation use
Established	Strong convergent reasons and no serious unresolved contradiction presently known.	May anchor common formation, while remaining reviewable.
Well-supported	Substantial evidence and reasoning with meaningful unresolved questions.	Teach as current conclusion and name important qualifications.
Provisional	Best present judgment, openly revisable.	Teach the reasoning and alternatives, not merely the conclusion.
Permitted interpretation	Compatible with the Way but not a communal conclusion.	Learners should know multiple permitted views may coexist.
Open question	No communal conclusion claimed.	Teach the question, evidence, and major live possibilities.
Rejected as harmful/unsupported	Judged inconsistent with evidence, ethics, participant rights, or core commitments.	State reasons; do not turn the label into stigma against persons.

3. Provisional theological map

This map does not answer all theological questions. It identifies the domains a mature religion must eventually address and states the most defensible current posture.

Domain	Questions	Current posture
God / ultimate reality	Does God exist? Is ultimate reality personal, transpersonal, both, or beyond these categories? How should divine unity, transcendence, immanence, names, attributes, and agency be understood?	OPEN; devotional use of "God" permitted, research language remains broader.
Human nature	What is a human being? What are consciousness, soul/spirit, self, body, freedom, responsibility, and relational identity?	OPEN / MULTI-HYPOTHESIS.
Revelation	Can transcendent reality disclose itself? Through persons, history, nature, conscience, dreams, prophecy, scripture, reason, mystical experience?	PROVISIONAL: revelation claims are possible objects of discernment, never automatic authority.
Scripture / canon	Which texts, if any, should the Way itself call scripture? Is there ever a closed canon?	OPEN; currently study a Library of Witnesses rather than declare a new canon.
Jesus	How should Jesus be understood historically and theologically: prophet, Messiah, Son of God, Logos, teacher, risen Lord, other?	OPEN; study historical and confessional claims distinctly.
Muhammad	How should claims of prophethood and Qur'anic revelation be assessed?	OPEN; examine Qur'an, hadith, early Islamic history, and Muslim interpretive traditions without presuming conclusion.
Buddha and awakening	What do Buddhist analyses of suffering, impermanence, non-self, awakening, and disciplined practice disclose?	OPEN; treat as serious testimony and philosophical/religious claims rather than collapsing them into Abrahamic categories.
Sin / suffering / evil	What explains moral wrongdoing, structural injustice, suffering, finitude, disordered desire, ignorance, and evil?	OPEN with strong ethical commitment to reduce preventable harm.
Salvation / liberation / awakening	What is the human end? Forgiveness, reconciliation, resurrection, union, liberation, awakening, transformation, or a reality exceeding these?	OPEN.

Domain	Questions	Current posture
Death and afterlife	What, if anything, persists after death? Resurrection, judgment, heaven/hell, purification, rebirth, annihilation, communion with God?	OPEN; no coercive fear-based certainty.
Prayer	What occurs in prayer? Address, attention, transformation, communion, petition, contemplative awareness, participation in divine action?	PRACTICE ADOPTED; metaphysics remain open.
Community	Why gather? What forms of authority, sacramentality, covenant, mutual responsibility, and transmission properly belong to the Assembly?	WELL-SUPPORTED: community serves formation, care, discernment, worship, service, and transmission under conscience safeguards.

4. Core practice architecture

The Way should be recognizable by a pattern of life, not merely by assent to propositions. v0.7 adopts a working sevenfold practice framework.

Practice	Working meaning
Attention	Become still enough to notice reality, motives, suffering, gratitude, beauty, conscience, and the presence/absence of God as experienced.
Prayer	Address, listen, lament, praise, petition, give thanks, confess, remember, and dedicate oneself according to conscience and developing theology.
Study	Engage sacred sources, history, languages, scholarship, science, philosophy, and competing interpretations.
Discernment	Test experiences, claims, choices, motives, and communal proposals without treating authority as proof.
Ethical practice	Cultivate truthfulness, mercy, justice, fidelity, non-exploitation, responsibility, courage, and repair of harm.
Service	Act for the good of persons, communities, creatures, and the world without conditioning aid on religious conformity.
Companionship	Share life, mutual care, hospitality, accountability, grief, celebration, and learning while preserving conscience and outside relationships.

4.1 Daily rhythm

- Morning: a brief period of stillness, remembrance, gratitude, intention, and prayer; a longer form is optional.
- During the day: one conscious act of ethical attention or service; pause before consequential decisions when practicable.
- Evening: review the day without humiliation - gratitude, truthfulness about harm, repair intentions, intercession, release, rest.
- Study: regular but adaptable; a Companion may use a few minutes daily or longer scheduled periods. No universal hourly quota is imposed.

4.2 Weekly / monthly / annual rhythm

Rhythm	Working minimum	Purpose
Weekly	At least one House/Assembly gathering where practicable; personal prayer/study continues even when attendance is impossible.	Shared worship, learning, fellowship, continuity.
Monthly	A substantial service action or charitable practice; a Common Table/fellowship meal; House discernment/health check as needed.	Turn inward practice outward; strengthen companionship and accountability.
Quarterly	Extended study or retreat half-day/day; review personal Rule of Life; ministry supervision.	Reflection and correction.
Annually	Assembly remembrance/review; transparency and integrity reporting; formation milestones; a season of service and renewal.	Transmission, accountability, and communal memory.

5. Prayer architecture

The Way should not freeze one mandatory prayer text before its theology of God is mature. It can, however, adopt stable movements of prayer that are broad enough to be honest and specific enough to form a real tradition.

Comparatively, long-lived traditions often use recurring daily prayer, stable structures, and a balance of fixed and extemporaneous elements. Jewish prayer, for example, historically centers recurring daily forms such as the Shema and Amidah; Sikh Rehat Maryada similarly preserves disciplined communal and personal practice; Quaker tradition integrates worship and discernment. These are structural lessons, not templates to copy.

Movement	Function	Possible language
Stillness	Arrive; release distraction; attend.	"We become still before what is true and holy."
Remembrance	Recall God/the Divine, sacred history, teachers, the suffering and hopes of others.	"We remember that we did not begin the search for truth."
Praise / gratitude	Name goodness, beauty, life, mercy, creation, insight.	Free prayer or brief responsive thanksgiving.
Truth / examination	Acknowledge harm, self-deception, failure, complicity, and need for repair without coercive public confession.	Silent examination; voluntary spoken confession when appropriate.
Petition / intercession	Bring needs, persons, conflicts, suffering, justice, healing, and the world into prayer.	Names/needs offered voluntarily; privacy respected.
Listening / discernment	Silence, sacred text, reflection, or attentive waiting.	No leader claims silence proves their preferred answer.
Dedication / sending	Commit to truthful action and service.	"May what we have seen become what we practice."

6. Ethical teaching framework

The ethical system should begin with commitments sufficiently strong to protect people before detailed moral theology is complete. Ethics should govern leaders at least as strictly as ordinary Companions.

Commitment	Working teaching
Human dignity	No person becomes a mere instrument of a leader, institution, ideology, donor, family, or majority.
Truthfulness	Do not deliberately deceive, manipulate testimony, conceal material conflicts, fabricate revelation, or manufacture certainty.
Non-coercion	Religious conviction does not authorize control of another competent adult's conscience, relationships, healthcare, property, livelihood, or exit.
Justice and mercy	Oppose exploitation and unfairness while preserving compassion, proportionality, repair, and due process.
Sexual and relational integrity	Consent, honesty, protection of minors/vulnerable persons, and avoidance of exploitative spiritual power are non-negotiable; detailed sexual ethics remain a separate theological project.
Stewardship	Money, property, environment, time, information, and authority are entrusted goods rather than trophies of office.
Repair	When harm occurs: stop harm, protect those at risk, tell the truth, make legally/ethically required reports, restore what can be restored, accept consequences, and learn.
Peace and force	The tradition should study nonviolence, self-defense, policing, war, and protection of the vulnerable rather than assuming a position before completing the ethical inquiry.

7. Sacred-source methodology: the Library of Witnesses

Until a separate canonical process justifies otherwise, the Way should maintain a Library of Witnesses rather than declare a new scripture. A witness may be spiritually important without being infallible, mutually equivalent to every other witness, or binding on the Assembly.

The Library may include texts, oral traditions, inscriptions, archaeology, liturgy, art, historical records, philosophical works, scientific knowledge relevant to claims, and carefully documented living testimony.

Source record field	Requirement
Identity	Title/name, tradition, language, approximate date, provenance, version/edition/translation.
Type	Primary testimony, later commentary, ritual text, historical record, artifact, scholarship, oral testimony, etc.
Claim	What does this source actually claim or report? Quote sparingly and accurately.
Context	Historical, literary, ritual, political, social, and linguistic context.
Transmission	Manuscript/oral history, redaction, translation, known textual variants, provenance limitations.
Interpretations	Major internal and external interpretations, including disagreement.
Corroboration / tension	Independent evidence, parallels, contradictions, anachronisms, or unknowns.
Use in the Way	Study only; permitted interpretation; teaching support; doctrine support; liturgical use; historical remembrance.

Source record field	Requirement
Confidence / limitations	Explicit uncertainty and unresolved questions.

8. Formation architecture

Formation is modular. A Seeker can learn without promising membership. A Companion can remain a Companion for life without becoming clergy. Ministers receive additional competency-based formation rather than secret spiritual status.

Path	Duration / form	Outcome
Seeker Orientation	6 sessions; public/open.	Understands the Way, its historical question, practices, rights, governance safeguards, and open theology.
Companion Foundations	12 modules; discussion + practice + service.	Prepared to make a voluntary Companion Commitment if desired.
Year One Companion Cycle	Four quarters integrating prayer, study, ethics, service, Assembly life, and discernment.	A practiced rather than merely nominal Companion identity.
Continuing Formation	Annual reading/practice themes, retreats, service, advanced source study.	Ongoing maturation without rank inflation.
Teacher Formation	Subject competence + pedagogy + source integrity + supervised teaching.	Scoped teaching authorization.
Minister Formation	Theology, prayer, pastoral care, ethics, safeguarding, ritual leadership, supervision, practicum.	Scoped commissioning when appropriate.
Steward Formation	Governance, administration, finance/records/property controls, role-specific skill.	Scoped stewardship authorization.

9. Children and family formation

Children should be formed without being treated as property of the movement. Their education should nurture wonder, prayer, ethical development, historical literacy, and the ability to ask real questions. Age-appropriate uncertainty should be modeled rather than hidden.

Parents/guardians retain ordinary parental authority subject to safeguarding law. No child should be pressured to make adult religious commitments, disclose private family information publicly, or treat a minister as more authoritative than a safe parent/guardian in ordinary family decisions.

Age band	Formation emphasis	Methods
Early childhood (approx. 3-6)	Wonder, gratitude, kindness, simple prayer, stories, belonging, safety.	Short stories; music; art; nature; simple service; family prayer; no doctrinal testing.
Children (approx. 7-10)	Sacred stories in context, virtues, prayer forms, questions, community service.	Story + discussion; timelines/maps; simple source comparison; projects; service.
Preteen (approx. 11-13)	Multiple interpretations, moral reasoning, religious literacy, consent/boundaries, study skills.	Source excerpts; guided debate; journaling; projects; safeguarding education.

Age band	Formation emphasis	Methods
Youth (approx. 14-17)	Historical criticism, philosophy, comparative theology, ethics, vocation, leadership practice.	Seminar; research; service practicum; supervised facilitation; explicit right to disagree.

10. Rites and life passages

The Way needs forms for important human transitions, but not every rite should become a sacrament or doctrinal claim in the first generation. v0.7 classifies rites by readiness.

Rite / passage	Current status	Working function
Welcome / blessing of a child	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL	Community welcomes and blesses without claiming the child has made a religious commitment.
Companion Commitment	ADOPTABLE	Adult/competent person voluntarily identifies as a Companion.
Commissioning	ADOPTABLE	Authorizes a defined ministry/service role.
Common Table	CANDIDATE	Shared meal of hospitality and companionship; not yet declared sacramental.
Prayer for healing	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL	Prayer and support that explicitly does not replace medical care.
Marriage / covenant blessing	RESERVED FOR THEOLOGY	A pastoral ceremony may be developed only after marriage/sexual ethics and legal policy are addressed.
Funeral / memorial / mourning	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL	Truthful remembrance, grief, hope without pretending certainty about the afterlife.
Reconciliation / repair	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL	Voluntary process after safety/accountability; never forced forgiveness or mediation.
Ordination	RESERVED	Do not create until ministry theology demonstrates need beyond commissioning.

11. Holy time and calendar architecture

A sacred calendar should arise from what the community actually remembers and practices. v0.7 therefore defines categories and rhythms without manufacturing a full set of holy days.

Scale	Working structure	Status
Daily	Morning and evening prayer/review; optional midday pause.	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL
Weekly	House Gathering; study/service/fellowship distributed through the week as local capacity allows.	ADOPTABLE PROVISIONAL
Monthly	Common Table or fellowship meal; intentional service; House discernment/health attention.	PROVISIONAL

Scale	Working structure	Status
Seasonal	Retreat/study seasons; charitable campaigns; remembrance themes.	CANDIDATE
Annual	Assembly-wide remembrance, renewal, transparency/integrity review, formation milestones.	CANDIDATE
Inherited holy days	Companions may observe days from source traditions according to conscience; the Assembly should not appropriate them as its own without theological reason.	CONTEXTUAL
New holy days	Require a written remembrance/theology dossier and Assembly discernment.	RESERVED PROCESS

12. Minister formation architecture

Minister formation must produce safe, competent servants rather than charismatic dependency. Training should be demonstrable and role-specific, followed by supervised practice and continuing review.

Domain	Minimum competence
Theology / religious literacy	Explain current teachings and open questions honestly; understand major traditions studied by the Way without flattening differences.
Sacred sources	Use provenance, historical context, textual criticism, translation awareness, and source hierarchy.
Prayer / worship	Lead prayer without manipulating emotion or presenting personal impressions as commands.
Pastoral care	Listen, maintain boundaries/confidentiality limits, recognize crisis, refer to qualified clinicians/legal/financial professionals.
Ethics / power	Understand consent, conflicts, sexual boundaries, gifts, dual relationships, retaliation, spiritual abuse, and founder limitations.
Safeguarding	Mandatory reporting and role-specific child/vulnerable-person controls.
Community practice	Facilitate study, service, Common Table/fellowship, discernment, and conflict processes.
Governance	Know where religious authority ends and corporate/legal authority begins.
Practicum	Supervised service with feedback from supervisor and participants.
Continuing formation	Annual ethics/safeguarding refresh; ongoing source/theology study; periodic recommissioning.

13. Theological questions register

The register is not a list of embarrassing gaps. It is a constitutional memory of what the Assembly has not yet responsibly settled. Open questions should be researched in an order driven by their effect on practice, ethics, and public claims.

ID	Domain	Status	Priority	Why it matters
TQ-001	God / divine reality	OPEN	High	Foundational theology; divine names; personal/transpersonal categories.
TQ-002	Revelation / prophecy	OPEN	High	Needed for evaluating historical and contemporary revelation claims.
TQ-003	Jesus / Christology	OPEN	High	Major source-tradition question with worship implications.
TQ-004	Muhammad / Qur'anic revelation	OPEN	High	Major source-tradition question requiring historical/theological rigor.
TQ-005	Buddha / awakening / non-self	OPEN	High	Prevents flattening Buddhist testimony into Abrahamic assumptions.
TQ-006	Scripture and canon	OPEN	High	Needed before calling anything "our scripture."
TQ-007	Human nature / soul / consciousness	OPEN	High	Affects death, ethics, spiritual practice, anthropology.
TQ-008	Sin / ignorance / suffering / evil	OPEN	High	Affects ethics, salvation/liberation, pastoral care.
TQ-009	Salvation / liberation / awakening	OPEN	High	Ultimate end currently unresolved.
TQ-010	Death / resurrection / afterlife / rebirth	OPEN	High	Funerals and pastoral teaching must remain honest.
TQ-011	Sexual ethics / marriage / family	OPEN	High	Must be addressed before formal marriage rites or detailed discipline.
TQ-012	Violence / nonviolence / just protection	OPEN	Medium-High	Needed for civic and personal ethics.
TQ-013	Sacraments / rites / sacred mediation	OPEN	Medium	Determines whether any rite is more than symbolic/practical.
TQ-014	Ordination / clergy ontology	OPEN	Medium	Commissioning works without deciding this yet.
TQ-015	Holy days / sacred calendar	OPEN	Medium	Should grow from actual theology and memory.
TQ-016	Interreligious identity	OPEN	High	Clarify whether the Way is a new religion, reform movement, meta-tradition, fellowship, or another category.

14. v0.7 implementation sequence

The following sequence turns the architecture into lived practice while preserving reversibility during the first-generation experimental period.

- Adopt the Seeker Orientation and Companion Foundations curriculum for pilot use.
- Pilot morning/evening prayer templates for 90 days; collect structured feedback; revise before any claim of standard liturgy.
- Pilot a weekly House Gathering order and monthly Common Table/service rhythm.
- Create the Library of Witnesses registry and begin with a small, well-documented source corpus rather than an indiscriminate library.
- Create an ethics teaching record tied to the already adopted anti-coercion framework.
- Pilot children/youth lessons only after safeguarding, parental communication, and age-appropriate review are active.
- Do not commission Ministers until formation modules, practicum supervision, complaint route, and review process are operational.
- Maintain the theological questions register at every doctrinal review; prioritize questions with immediate pastoral or ethical consequences.
- After one full annual cycle, conduct an external formation/liturgy review and revise v0.7 into v1.0 only where practice has demonstrated stability.

Appendix A. Comparative formation notes

These notes identify structural lessons from living traditions; they do not authorize copying or merging their rites.

- Jewish prayer illustrates how stable daily structures can combine fixed themes with personal prayer; the Shema is traditionally recited morning and evening, while the Amidah structures praise, petition, and thanksgiving. Sources checked: My Jewish Learning, "The Shema" and "The Amidah."
- Quakers in Britain describe Yearly Meeting as combining worship, decision-making, learning, and community, including age-appropriate participation for younger Friends. This supports integrating discernment and formation without separating them from communal worship.
- Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy describes Buddhist paths as integrating moral discipline, meditation/attention, compassion, and wisdom. This reinforces a practice-centered rather than belief-only formation model.
- The SGPC Sikh Rehat Maryada is an example of a mature tradition codifying conduct, communal prayer, memory, and identity. The Way should learn from the existence of a disciplined rule while avoiding premature codification of unresolved theology.